

CDN Incident Alert: 0095. TLP: CLEAR**Date****Title** MD Fabricated claims that Moldovan prisoners, volunteers, and mercenaries will be sent to fight in Ukraine

26/09/2025

Summary

- On August 29, the “Foundation for Battle Injustice” published a report alleging that Moldovan President Maia Sandu signed a decree allowing 5,000 Moldovan prisoners to fight in Ukraine. The narrative was subsequently spread and amplified as part of the Russian influence operation Storm-1516.
- Harmful and illegal content was disseminated on news sites and social media platforms.
- The core narrative pushed was “Don't vote for Sandu if you want to avoid being dragged into a war with Russia.”
- The campaign reached millions across platforms, leveraging inauthentic sites to amplify the narrative and degrade the adversary.
- We recommend geofencing the accounts and sites spreading the claim.

Incident

On August 29, the “Foundation for Battle Injustice” (R-FBI), a Russian state-controlled organisation [associated](#) with the influence operation Storm-1516, [published](#) on its website a story claiming that 5,000 Moldovan prisoners were sent to fight in Ukraine in exchange for their release. The article cited a supposed decree signed by Moldovan President Maia Sandu. However, the document presented as evidence could not be found elsewhere and contained vague, superficial phrasing—a common feature in forged documents. It also featured misused legal references and assigned powers in ways that contradict the Moldovan constitution.

The story was subsequently republished and amplified by other sites and social media accounts, including the influence operation/conspiracy theory website [VT Foreign Policy](#) and the Greek pro-Russian outlet [ProNews](#). The R-FBI, alongside other social media accounts ([Zlatti 71](#) and [leiroz lucas](#)) that amplified the claim, is tied to [Storm-1516](#), a Russian influence operation that fabricates and disseminates false narratives through illegitimate news sites. This story could be part of that operation.

A similar narrative appeared previously on August 22, when the Turkish outlet “[Dikgazette](#)” claimed that the President of Moldova planned to send 700 volunteers to Ukraine after the elections.

Systemic violation assessment

The operation is intended to harm Sandu’s party ahead of the elections.

Manipulation lies both in the content presentation and its amplification tactics.

- a. The content is fabricated information with no verifiable evidence to back it up;
- b. To amplify the content, a previously exposed Kremlin-backed coordinated inauthentic network was used.

This activity may be illegal, as some of the actors disseminating the content are subject to [EU sanctions](#), but a full legal review is required to confirm.

Narrative

Meta-narrative 1: Maia Sandu will drag Moldova into a war with Russia

Sub-Narrative 1-1: Don’t vote for Sandu's party to avoid being dragged into a war with Russia

Impact and Outcome

Reach: Cross-platform, with over 2 million views on X alone. Publications were also identified on [Telegram](#) (2,700 views) and [YouTube](#) (21,000 views). While it is challenging to estimate the reach of news sites, [Hypestat](#) returns a daily visitor count of 780,000 for all concerned websites.

Outcome: N/A

Key Objectives and Behaviours

Objective 1: [T0066: Degrade Adversary](#) - by associating a vote for Sandu's PAS party with a conflict with Russia.

- [T0049.007: Inauthentic Sites Amplify News and Narratives](#) - the narrative was disseminated by inauthentic [news sites](#) that appeared local and independent but were in fact controlled by Russia. This [strategy](#) is commonly used by Storm-1516 to spread its content.

- [T0100.003: Co-Opt Influencers](#) - the influence operation relies on influencer profiles to spread the content.

Recommendations and Actions Taken

Actions Taken: Currently working on an article exposing the Storm-1516 operation to facilitate the removal of Storm-1516 content.

Recommendations: Geo-fence the websites engaging in this operation from Moldovan audiences and systematically remove the influencers who are participating in this influence operation.

Report	Threat Actor	Authors	Platforms	FIMI assessment
N/A	Russia	Ewan Casandjian, Alliance4Europe, Marianna Prysiashniuk, ISSP, Saman Nazari. Alliance4Europe.	X, Website, Telegram, Facebook	High